

The Integrity of Sammā

Recently a contributor on the website “Theravada Pariyatti” submitted the following view of the evolution of the Pali word sammā in relation to its meaning of “right view.”

Content:

“The Evolution of Right View

The doctrine of Right View (sammā diṭṭhi), the pivotal first factor of the Noble Eightfold Path, serves as the foundation for all Buddhist thought and practice. Within the Theravada tradition, it is commonly categorized into two distinct tiers: mundane (lokiya) right view, which understands the ethical law of kamma and its fruits, and supramundane (lokuttara) right view, which constitutes the direct insight into the Four Noble Truths that leads to liberation. A compelling question within modern Buddhist scholarship is whether this precise, hierarchical distinction originates from the earliest teachings of the Buddha or represents a later scholastic development. A critical examination of the Pali Canon’s textual layers reveals that a significant body of scholarly opinion argues the latter: the formalized dichotomy of mundane and supramundane right view is a product of later systematization, essential for a growing religious community but not explicit in the Buddha’s original discourse.

The First Teaching: A Holistic Path to Liberation

The Noble Eightfold Path made its seminal appearance in the Buddha’s first sermon, the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (The Setting in Motion of the Wheel of Dhamma), delivered to his first five disciples in the Deer Park at Sarnath. In this foundational discourse, the Path is presented as the Fourth Noble Truth — the way leading to the cessation of suffering. Crucially, in this original context, the entire Path, including Right View, is framed in a supramundane context. It is introduced as an integrated, holistic package designed for one ultimate purpose: achieving liberation (Nibbana). There is no explicit analysis of its factors or a distinction between different levels of practice. The “Right View” of the First Sermon is implicitly the supramundane understanding that leads directly to enlightenment, appropriate for an audience of renunciates prepared for the highest teaching.

A Philosophical Imperative: Rejecting Metaphysics and the Problem of Rebirth

To understand why scholars question the later distinction, one must consider a core tension in the early teachings. The Buddha consistently discouraged metaphysical speculations, focusing instead on the pragmatic problem of suffering. This creates a philosophical problem for a literal interpretation of mundane right view, which often involves ensuring a favorable rebirth. As the user rightly points out, this seems

to conflict with the central doctrine of anatta (no-self). The idea of a fixed, enduring self that persists from life to life to enjoy the fruits of merit is a metaphysical concept the Buddha explicitly avoided. Scholars like Gombrich argue that teachings on kamma and rebirth were likely used by the Buddha as a skillful means (upāya), a conventional teaching to encourage ethical behavior and discourage hedonism, rather than a literal cosmological claim. The ultimate goal was always to uproot the clinging and ignorance that fuel the cycle of existence, not to secure a better position within it.

The Argument from Textual Chronology and Development

The core of the scholarly argument rests on textual criticism. Proponents of the “later development” theory note that the explicit pairing of lokiya and lokuttara sammādiṭṭhi is absent from what are widely considered the oldest parts of the Sutta Piṭaka, including the First Sermon. Texts such as the Sutta Nipāta present Right View in a more holistic and integrated manner.

In contrast, the detailed analysis and rigid classification of these two types of Right View are most prominently featured in the Abhidhamma Piṭaka and the classical Commentaries. These texts, composed centuries after the Buddha, are characterized by their drive to create a meticulous, systematic matrix of all existents. The mundane/supramundane distinction is a quintessential example of this project, providing a structured framework where none explicitly existed before, potentially moving beyond the Buddha’s pragmatic avoidance of metaphysical systematization.

Key Scholars and Their Contributions: Gombrich’s Thesis of “Reification”

Prominent scholars have championed this view. The esteemed Indologist Richard F. Gombrich, in his work *How Buddhism Began*, provides a particularly compelling framework. He argues that the Buddha’s original teachings were primarily ethical and psychological, not metaphysical. Gombrich contends that later scholasticism “reified” the Buddha’s metaphors and pragmatic concepts — turning psychological processes into literal, systematic, ontological realities.

For Gombrich, the formal distinction between mundane and supramundane right view is a product of this reification. The Buddha taught about kamma as a powerful ethical principle within a conventional reality, but later scholars took this framework literally and built upon it, creating a “mundane” level of truth and practice that was then distinguished from a higher, “supramundane” truth. This allowed the Sangha to accommodate both popular piety (focused on merit and rebirth) and monastic philosophy (focused on liberation), but, in Gombrich’s view, at the cost of creating a doctrinal system the Buddha himself might have avoided.

A specific textual example supporting this thesis is found in the work of translators Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli¹ and Bhikkhu Bodhi². They point to the Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta (MN 9), a primary source for the definition of mundane right view, and suggest its analytical style is “more typical of the Abhidhamma and the commentaries” and thus likely a “later insertion in the canon.”

The Counterargument: A Latent Distinction

However, a compelling counterargument suggests that while the terminology and explicit analysis may be late, the practical distinction itself is latent in the early teachings. The Buddha was a master of pedagogical skill (upāya-kusala), tailoring his teachings to his audience. His discourses to laypeople often emphasized generosity, virtue, and the law of kamma — the concerns of mundane right view. His instructions to monastics, meanwhile, plunged directly into the nature of clinging, cessation, and no-self — the concerns of supramundane right view. From this perspective, the Abhidhamma and Commentaries did not create a new doctrine but merely made an implicit, practical distinction explicit and philosophically robust.

Conclusion: An Indispensable Map for the Path

In conclusion, the historical evidence is clear: the Noble Eightfold Path was first presented as a unified path to liberation, consistent with the Buddha’s discouragement of metaphysical speculation. The evidence from textual criticism and scholars like Gombrich strongly supports the thesis that the formal classification of Right View into mundane and supramundane tiers is a later scholastic development. This development solved practical problems for a growing Sangha but may have also created a philosophical tension with the doctrine of anatta. This does not diminish the distinction’s value; rather, it highlights the dynamic and evolving nature of the Buddhist tradition as it sought to preserve, explain, and propagate the Dhamma. Ultimately, the two levels of Right View provide a crucial map for practitioners, reflecting the tradition’s profound understanding of the graduated nature of human spiritual development.”

¹ **Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli** was born as Osbert John S. Moore in England in 1905. A graduate of Exeter College, Oxford, he worked as a literary editor before becoming disillusioned with Western materialism. In 1948, he traveled to Sri Lanka and ordained as a Theravāda Buddhist monk at the Island Hermitage under the name Ñāṇamoli. A renowned brilliant Pali translator and scholar, he is best known for rendering major Pāli texts into English, including *The Path of Purification (Visuddhimagga)* and *The Middle Length Discourses of the Buddha (Majjhima Nikāya)*.

² **Bhikkhu Bodhi** was born Jeffrey Block in Brooklyn, New York, in 1944. He earned a Ph.D. in philosophy from Claremont Graduate University and was ordained as a Theravāda Buddhist monk in Sri Lanka in 1972 under the guidance of Ven. Balangoda Ānanda Maitreya. A preeminent scholar and translator of the Pāli Canon, he is best known for his translations of the *Majjhima Nikāya*, *Saṃyutta Nikāya*, and *Aṅguttara Nikāya*. He has served as editor of the Buddhist Publication Society.

Examining the editorial-like assertions made in this piece, I made two observations. [Note: I employ the word “editorial” for ease of use.] Insofar as my initial observation; it appears that the contextual framework and presentation of this editorial has the distinct essence of an AI response to an inquiry or series of inquiries. Whether this is the case is of little importance to the larger topic under discussion. My second observation is far more complex. This editorial reveals a debate that has been argued for some time, particularly by intellectual scholars (e.g. Gombrich³) who pry apart the Pali texts, endlessly discussing ontology, etymology, epigraphy, philosophy, and so on, without any real direct experience with the practice of the Dhamma in relation to the very things they argue or research. Extraction of singular words outside of the context of the entire corpus of the early Pali texts is, frankly, almost pointless, unless one is simply observing the entomological evolution of a word, and no more. But, to categorize the meaning of a word that the Buddha employed, as recorded in the early Pali texts, based solely on etymology, modern philosophical thought, and even ontologically, is, as I will discuss, veers dangerously off the mark of knowing and understanding the force of meaning of certain words within the context of the Dhamma itself.

Reclaiming Sammā: Right View (Samma Diṭṭhi) and the Path to Liberation

One of the more subtle, yet significant challenges in interpreting the Buddha's teachings is the tendency to impose contemporary or scholastic frameworks upon terms that originally carried a profoundly pragmatic and liberating function. Nowhere is this more evident than in the evolution of the Pāli word sammā, conventionally translated into English as "right," particularly in the context of the Eightfold Noble Path.

The word sammā does not simply mean "right" in the sense of "correct" or "morally good." Its etymology traces to the root saṃ- (together, completely) and mā (measure), suggesting something properly aligned, balanced, accurate, or in harmony with the whole Dhamma. In the earliest Pali texts, sammā functions as an adverb meaning "in the correct way" or "appropriately," and its use throughout the Eightfold Path reflects the Buddha's deep concern with orientation rather than orthodoxy. When the Buddha prefixes each factor of the path with sammā, he is indicating not just correctness but completion and alignment with liberation. As stated in the Majjhima Nikāya 117 (Mahācattārīsaka Sutta):

"Right view, I say, is twofold: there is right view that is accompanied by taints, partaking of merit, ripening in the acquisitions; and there is right view that is noble, taintless, supramundane, a factor of the path."

Now, if this early 19th century rendering were to be reframed with the understanding of the actual contextual meaning of the word sammā, taking its meaning in relation to the entire corpus of the early Pali texts, the sutta would accurately read:

³ Richard Gombrich is Boden Professor of Sanskrit at Oxford University, and Fellow of Balliol College. He has visited Sri Lanka eight times, living for over a year in a Sinhalese village, and is the author of the standard work *Precept and Practice: Traditional Buddhism in the Rural Highlands of Ceylon* (Oxford University Press, 197a) and is honorary Secretary of the Pali Text Society.

"Accurate view, I say, is twofold: there is accurate view that is accompanied by taints, partaking of merit, ripening in the acquisitions; and there is accurate view that is noble, taintless, supramundane, a factor of the path."

This canonical distinction undercuts any argument that the two-tier model of Right View is a mere commentarial overlay. It is foundational. To claim, as some modern scholarly texts do, that this distinction is a later scholastic invention is to ignore or dismiss primary source evidence. Sammā-diṭṭhi as presented in Majjhima Nikāya 9 (Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta) is carefully analyzed through the lens of causality:

"What, friends, is right view? Knowledge of suffering, knowledge of the origin of suffering, knowledge of the cessation of suffering, knowledge of the way leading to the cessation of suffering—this is called right view."

Again, applying the principle of the actual contextual meaning of the word sammā, taking its meaning in relation to the entire corpus of the early Pali texts, the sutta would accurately read:

"What, friends, is accurate view? Knowledge of suffering, knowledge of the origin of suffering, knowledge of the cessation of suffering, knowledge of the way leading to the cessation of suffering—this is called accurate view."

The Buddha discusses Right View in relation to kamma, nutriment, the Four Noble Truths, and dependent origination, showing clearly that mundane understanding builds the ethical and cognitive structure from which supramundane insight emerges. Moreover, Saṃyutta Nikāya 12.15 (Kaccānagotta Sutta) frames Right View as that which avoids both eternalism and annihilationism:

"This world, Kaccāna, for the most part depends upon a duality—upon the notion of existence and the notion of nonexistence. But for one who sees the origin of the world as it really is with correct wisdom, there is no notion of nonexistence in regard to the world. And for one who sees the cessation of the world as it really is with correct wisdom, there is no notion of existence in regard to the world."

Again, applying a more cogent use of the Pali word sammā, in relation to the essence of the Buddha's entire teachings, the same sutta might read as follows:

*"This world, Kaccāna, for the most part depends upon a duality—upon the notion of existence and the notion of nonexistence. But for one who sees the origin of the world as it really is with **accurate** wisdom, there is no notion of nonexistence in regard to the world. And for one who sees the cessation of the world as it really is with **accurate** wisdom, there is no notion of existence in regard to the world."*

The Buddha's formulation of the Middle Way here directly supports the idea that sammā is that which leads one out of philosophical traps into clarity through dependent arising (paṭiccasamuppāda). When claims are made that mundane Right View conflicts with anattā, it not only misrepresents the Canon's presentation of kamma (which is defined as cetanā — intention — in Aṅguttara Nikāya 6.63):

"It is volition, monks, that I call kamma; for having willed, one acts by body, speech, and mind."

...but it also leans toward a nihilistic reading that denies continuity without a self. **The Buddha's** teachings consistently **reject both extremes**. Furthermore, the Buddha's instruction in Majjhima Nikāya 60 (Apaṭṭakavagga: Apaṭṭaka Sutta) illustrates the value of adopting "safe bet" views:

"If there is another world, and if there is the fruit and result of good and bad actions, then it is possible that I might fare after death as one who has done good actions. But if there is no other world, and no fruit and result of good and bad actions, then I shall live here happily, free from enmity and ill will."

This isn't endorsement of blind belief, but rather one of confidence, a strategic adoption of views that lead to wholesome conduct and liberation.

The issue, then, is not whether the word sammā has evolved in commentarial literature, but whether its function has been obscured by **over-intellectualization**. When sammā-ditṭhi is reduced to historical analysis or doctrinal system-building devoid of its liberative and accurate function, the term is degraded. This is precisely the kind of error the Buddha warned against in Majjhima Nikāya 22 (Alagaddūpama Sutta):

"Just as a man would grasp a snake wrongly by the tail, and it would bite him and cause death or deadly suffering, so too, here, some foolish people learn the Dhamma for the sake of criticizing others or for winning debates... they misuse the Dhamma, and it leads to their harm."

The Buddha further warns in Majjhima Nikāya 2 (Sabbāsava Sutta) and Dīgha Nikāya 1 (Brahmajāla Sutta) against the jungle of speculative views, emphasizing that the **proliferation of unhelpful theorizing entangles the mind**:

"This speculative view is a thicket of views, a wilderness of views, a contortion of views... not leading to dispassion, to cessation, to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to Nibbāna."

In the Aṅguttara Nikāya 4.77, he explicitly declares certain questions as *acinteyya* (unconjecturable):

"There are these four unconjecturables... He who conjectures about these would go mad and experience vexation."

And what, finally, is the test of what is sammā? The Buddha offers it plainly in Majjhima Nikāya 58 (Abhaya Sutta):

"In the case of words that the Tathāgata knows to be untrue, incorrect, and unbeneficial, he does not say them. In the case of words that are true and correct but unbeneficial, he does not say them. In the case of words that are true, correct, and beneficial, he knows the proper time to say them."

And, again, applying a more cogent use of the Pali word sammā, in relation to the essence of the Buddha's entire teachings, the same sutta might read as follows:

*"In the case of words that the Tathāgata knows to be untrue, **inaccurate**, and unbeneficial, he does not say them. In the case of words that are true and **accurate** but unbeneficial, he does not say them. In the case of words that are true, **accurate**, and beneficial, he knows the proper time to say them."*

If the alternative intellectual meaning of the Pali word sammā reduces its meaning then it does not reduce greed, hatred, and delusion, then it is not in alignment with the path—it is not sammā. And so, when modern readers become tangled in over-interpretation or cast doubt on core concepts through an academic lens, they risk degrading what the Buddha emphasized as knowable, testable, and practical. The Dhamma is not a metaphysical abstraction, but a path leading out of dukkha. As such, sammā-diṭṭhi cannot be understood through intellectual critique alone. It must be tested in experience, by whether it leads one closer to cessation, to dispassion, to release.

In a time when the teachings of the Buddha are increasingly filtered through cultural, devotional, and academic lenses, the recovery of the Buddha's original voice becomes all the more urgent. And that voice, if the early suttas are to be trusted, was never concerned with winning arguments, but with ending suffering. Sammā-diṭṭhi, in this sense, is not an opinion, nor a belief—it is a vantage point from which the path becomes visible. To understand sammā is to understand the Dhamma. And to preserve its meaning is to preserve the very heart of the path to liberation.

An esteemed colleague of mine, who is a Physicist as well as an accomplished Pali scholar, Dr. Lal Ariyaratna Pinaduage, writes extensively about sammā. Dr. Pinaduage's work of many decades is dedicated to recovering what he calls the "pure Dhamma" as taught by the Buddha. His research often emphasizes returning to the Pāli roots, avoiding later accretions or metaphysical baggage.

His research has examined the true meaning of the roots of "Sam" / "Sammā", and both perceptual distortions, including the mundane vs ultimate reality debate. He contends that when sammā is equated too much with advanced meditative states (only in Satipaṭṭhāna Bhūmi, etc.), uninformed people might think sammā is inaccessible unless one is already a meditator or privileged with deep retreat experiences. That obscures the canonical teaching that sammā factors are progressive and inclusive (even ethical beliefs, correct conduct, etc.).

Symbolic or etymological speculation, when presented without canonical support, can lead people into "chatter" or unnecessary philosophical knots. This is precisely what the Buddha warns against: spending time on views that do not lead to dispassion, insight, or liberation (see Aṅguttara Nikāya 4.77, Majjhima Nikāya 63).

Overemphasis on "mundane vs supramundane" progress, if treated as strict levels, can create a view of spirituality as hierarchical or esoteric rather than universal — which may lead to elitism rather than inspiring practice. But at the same time, integrating perception, conditionality, sammā distortion — these can help recover something of sammā's depth, if done carefully — i.e., staying grounded in what the early teachings themselves say (e.g. Majjhima Nikāya 117, Saṃyutta Nikāya 12.15, Majjhima Nikāya 9).

True meaning of *sammā* cannot be limited to intellectual correctness or doctrinal acceptance. Canonical evidence insists *sammā* is functional, experiential, transformative, always in service of ending dukkha. The distinction mundane / supramundane concerns are valid according to suttas (e.g. Majjhima Nikāya 117), but should not be turned into a rigid ladder that diminishes the role of everyday practice, ethics, or foundational view.

Dr. Pinaduage clarifies what *sammā* requires (clear perception, ethical conduct, wisdom). But when they risk making *sammā* into a rarefied state that excludes most practitioners, then they diverge from the Buddha's repeated message that the path is accessible to many levels.

The term *sammā*, so often translated rather casually as "right," demands from us a level of precision that transcends mere semantic convention. It is a word that, like many in the early Pāli canon, possesses a rich texture of meaning, one that resists shallow interpretation and instead invites us into a deeper contemplation of functional, epistemic alignment with truth. If we are to apply the analytical methodology reminiscent of mathematical physicist and philosopher Sir Roger Penrose, we must begin not with assertions, but with an examination of form, coherence, and invariance under transformation.

In this light, the Eightfold Noble Path itself may be regarded as a dynamic system—an interdependent structure whose stability arises from the coherent functioning of each of its components. Within this system, *sammā* is not a static label applied to the path's eight factors, but an operational quality that signals congruence with the governing principle of the Dhamma: the cessation of dukkha. In physics, one might call such a principle a conservation law—a law of transformation invariant under change of conditions. So too does *sammā* imply continuity across stages of development: from ethical alignment, through mental purification, to liberative insight.

Yet, much like the tendency in modern theoretical physics to conflate mathematical formalism with ontological truth, there has been a similar tendency in Buddhist scholarship to conflate systematic categorization with authentic insight. Consider, for instance, the increasingly common claim that the two-tiered classification of Right View—mundane and supramundane—is a scholastic invention alien to the original teachings. This assertion rests precariously on a presumption of textual hierarchy, assuming that what is early is necessarily more authentic, and what is later must therefore be synthetic or spurious. But the canonical record itself resists such simplification. In the Majjhima Nikāya 117, the Buddha clearly states:

"Right view, I say, is twofold: there is right view that is accompanied by taints, partaking of merit, ripening in the acquisitions; and there is right view that is noble, taintless, supramundane, a factor of the path."

Again, applying the principle of the actual contextual meaning of the word *sammā*, as was intended by the Buddha, and taking its meaning in relation to the entire corpus of the early Pali texts, the sutta might read:

*"**Accurate** view, I say, is twofold: there is **accurate** view that is accompanied by taints, partaking of merit, ripening in the acquisitions; and there is **accurate** view that is noble, taintless, supramundane, a factor of the path."*

This bifurcation is not an imposition, but an articulation of sammā as it functions in two domains: the causal and the transcendental. In physical terms, this would be akin to the distinction between a classical system governed by probabilistic behavior and a quantum system governed by superposition and collapse. Both obey consistent internal logic, but operate within different regimes of interpretive framework. One leads to beneficial rebirth and refinement of character; the other to cessation itself.

Furthermore, attempts to portray mundane right view—particularly belief in kamma and rebirth—as "merely skillful means" conflict with the internal logic of the Buddha's framework. As Saṃyutta Nikāya 12.15 (Kaccānagotta Sutta) reveals:

"This world, Kaccāna, for the most part depends upon a duality—upon the notion of existence and the notion of nonexistence... One who sees dependent origination as it really is, with correct (accurate) wisdom, has no notion of existence or nonexistence."

Here, we are in the presence of a precision not unlike what Penrose demands when differentiating between intuitive plausibility and mathematical necessity. The Buddha is not interested in metaphysical conjecture, but in the cognitive structure of suffering and its cessation—a system of conditional relations whose intelligibility lies in their utility, not in their speculative elaboration.

It is precisely here that modern conjecture, veiled in academic neutrality, risks distorting sammā into the very metaphysical abstraction the Buddha sought to displace. When views about views multiply without reference to cessation, we enter the terrain that Majjhima Nikāya 2 and Dīgha Nikāya 1 warned against: the jungle of views, a contortion of speculation. As the Majjhima Nikāya 22 teaches:

"Some foolish people learn the Dhamma for the sake of criticizing others or for winning debates... they misuse the Dhamma, and it leads to their harm."

Contrast this with Majjhima Nikāya 58, in which the Buddha lays down the functional criterion for speech (and by extension, analysis):

"In the case of words that are true, correct (accurate), and beneficial, he knows the proper time to say them."

This principle aligns remarkably with a heuristic coined by Sir Roger Penrose; that any proposition must be tested not only by its internal consistency, but by its ability to produce results in the realm it claims to describe. Sammā-dīṭṭhi, then, is not simply a correct belief, but a cognitive attunement to the conditions that lead to liberation. Its truth is not abstract but operational—much like the wavefunction in quantum theory, it is not observable directly, but only in its effects.

Dr. Pinaduge has argued that sammā emerges most fully in the context of *perceptual clarity*—particularly within the Satipaṭṭhāna bhūmi. There is much merit to this. To perceive without distortion, to see without avijjā (ignorance) or clinging, is to be in alignment with sammā. However, we must be careful not to mistake the depth of a state for the exclusivity of its insight. Sammā-dīṭṭhi is available not only in profound absorption, but in every moment of ethical clarity, every refusal to harm, every choice to see suffering clearly and respond with wisdom. The Pāli canon confirms this perspective in the Majjhima Nikāya 9, where the Buddha defines Right View as:

"Knowledge of suffering, knowledge of the origin of suffering, knowledge of the cessation of suffering, knowledge of the way leading to the cessation of suffering—this is called right (accurate) view."

This is not speculation. This is an equation, not dissimilar to the Dirac equation or Penrose's spin network, it encodes profound insight through structural simplicity. Each term unfolds the nature of the mind and its potential transformation. Each term is a vector pointing toward freedom.

To understand sammā is to grasp not only the shape of rightness (accuracy) but the direction of it—a dynamic movement toward cessation. It is the gravitational center of the Buddha's teaching: every path factor orbits around it. To degrade it through intellectual detachment or historical reduction is to lose the coherence of the system itself.

Sammā is not merely the opposite of "wrong." It is the signature of alignment with the fabric of reality, the mark of an insight not constrained by theory, but realized in release. And in this, it resembles nothing so much as a law of nature, tested by its results, enduring by its effect, and guiding by its presence. To preserve its meaning is not to entomb it in scholarship, but to live it, to walk the path it illumines, and to see for oneself that sammā is not just the beginning of the path, but its culmination.

Framework on Which I Base My Response

The framework I developed to explore the question of the meaning of the word sammā follows:

My analysis raises several deep and necessary questions about the Pāli word *sammā*, the structure of the Noble Eightfold Path, and whether later scholastic distinctions (such as *mundane* vs *supramundane* Right View) obscure or clarify the Buddha's original teachings. I examine the certain philosophical assumptions regarding the Pali word sammā, particularly in light of what we know about *sammā* and the Buddha's epistemological pragmatism — his rejection of speculation in favor of liberating knowledge.

CORE QUESTION

Does the historical or conceptual evolution of the term *sammā* compromise or clarify the Buddha's original intent?

My key concern

"Whether or not the word evolved, shouldn't we return to the earliest known usage and context of the term sammā to understand its meaning authentically — as a function of liberation, not metaphysical elaboration?"

I believe that this is precisely the right question. Einstein is quoted as having once made the statement: "If I had an hour to solve a problem, I'd spend 55 minutes thinking about the problem and 5 minutes thinking about the solution."

1. Does the conceptual meaning of *sammā* evolve over time? And does that matter?

Yes, the conceptual framing of *sammā* evolved — particularly in post-canonical systems like the Abhidhamma and commentarial literature. However:

- In early texts (e.g., Saṃyutta Nikāya 45.8, Saṃyutta Nikāya 56.11), *sammā* clearly refers to that which is aligned with insight into the Four Noble Truths.
- The later distinction into *mundane* (lokiya) and *supramundane* (lokuttara) views reflects a systematization, not necessarily a contradiction of the early use — but it shifts the context of *sammā* from pragmatic liberation to analytical categorization.

Thus, it does matter if the meaning of *sammā* shifts from being about what is “conducive to liberation” to being a formalized ladder of beliefs about karma, rebirth, and merit. That shift reflects philosophical assumptions not consistent with the Buddha’s emphasis on what leads to the end of dukkha.

2. What are the philosophical assumptions embedded in the position of the comment?

The commentary makes a strong case, but it implicitly assumes several things that deserve scrutiny:

Valid Observations:

- The early teachings are pragmatic, not metaphysical: This aligns with the Buddha’s repeated silence on unanswerable questions (e.g., Saṃyutta Nikāya 44.10).
- The distinction between lokiya and lokuttara Right View is not in the earliest discourses: This is accurate — it appears later and primarily in Abhidhamma and commentaries, not in early suttas like Saṃyutta Nikāya 56.11 or Dīgha Nikāya 22.
- The idea of “view” becoming reified into metaphysics contradicts the core insight of anattā: Also, accurate. The Buddha’s rejection of eternalism and annihilationism (see Majjhima Nikāya 1) shows he wasn’t interested in *ontology*, but in *cessation*.

Problematic Assumptions:

- The comment suggests that because the distinction between mundane and supramundane right view came later, it is less valid or distorting. But this assumes that early equals authentic and later equals scholastic excess. While that can be true, it’s an oversimplification.
- It assumes that *right view* can be historically dissected without considering the Buddha’s pedagogical strategy: he taught differently to different audiences. The lack of technical distinction in early sermons may be intentional, not a sign of absence.

3. How does *sammā* relate to the entirety of the Buddha's teaching?

This is perhaps the most important question. And the answer is:

The word *sammā* is not just a modifier for "view," "speech," or "action." It embodies the entire orientation of the Buddha's teaching — that each component of the path must be aligned with the cessation of suffering, not merely "correct" in a moral or intellectual sense.

This reflects several principles:

- Dependent origination (*paṭiccasamuppāda*): View is conditioned. Only a view that leads to dispassion, cessation, and relinquishment is *sammā* (see *Majjhima Nikāya* 117).
- The Noble Search (*Majjhima Nikāya* 26): The Buddha defines his entire awakening as a search for that which is not subject to birth, aging, and death. *Sammā-diṭṭhi* points directly to that.
- Not "beliefs," but penetrative seeing: The Buddha never asks for blind belief. He says in *Majjhima Nikāya* 2 that *Right View is seeing and understanding as it actually is*.

So, to define *sammā* apart from its function in the cessation of *dukkha* is to distort its meaning. Whether one divides it into two or not, its core essence remains: it must be liberating.

4. The danger of reification — and why it matters

Quoting Gombrich, reifying the concept of *sammā-diṭṭhi* — turning it into a metaphysical *thing* rather than a process or function — contradicts the very spirit of the Buddha's teaching. Furthermore, this parallels the Buddha's silence on unknowables (*avyākata*), where he repeatedly emphasized:

"Does this view lead to dispassion, cessation, and awakening? If not, it is not the Dhamma." (*Saṃyutta Nikāya* 12.48; *Saṃyutta Nikāya* 22.3)

While the comment is deeply insightful, it contains implicit assumptions that deserve cautious scrutiny:

1. It is correct in identifying that the word *sammā* in early texts is pragmatic, liberating, and non-metaphysical.
2. It rightly notes that the technical split into "mundane" and "supramundane" is absent from the Buddha's early teachings as recorded in the earliest Pali texts.
3. But it assumes that later distinctions are distortions rather than pedagogical expansions.
4. It risks treating historical development as linear degradation, rather than as interpretive adaptation.

The core meaning of *sammā* must always be understood not in terms of hierarchy or classification, but in terms of its function: Does it lead one to see *dukkha*, understand the Dhamma, and progress toward liberation? If not, it cannot rightly be called *sammā*, no matter how doctrinally sophisticated it appears.